

AGENTS OF REDIRECTION

DONELLA MEADOWS, ALEXANDRE MONNIN, PIERRE LÉVY

<https://chatgpt.com/share/6a70d5bd-a5b4-83e9-b9ae-6573c56b05a3>

I think there is a remarkably coherent trajectory from Monnin's 2013 thesis to his current work. What has changed is not the direction of his thought, but its center of gravity. The philosophy of the Web has progressively become a philosophy of ecological limits and of the transformation—not merely the critique—of technical systems.

Given the discussions we've had about Donella Meadows, AI agents, and socio-technical systems, I would summarize this evolution as follows.

1. The 2013 thesis: understanding the Web as an ontological object

In *Vers une philosophie du Web* (2013), Monnin was primarily interested in what the Web is.

His questions were things like:

- What kind of object is a webpage?
- What makes a hyperlink philosophically interesting?
- How do digital objects persist despite continuous modification?
- What happens when software, documents and infrastructure become inseparable?

Rather than treating the Web as "a technology", he treated it as an ecology of interconnected digital beings.

Several recurring ideas already appear:

- relations matter more than isolated objects;
- maintenance matters as much as creation;
- digital objects are processes rather than fixed entities;
- infrastructures become invisible precisely when they function well.

Those themes resonate strongly with later work.

2. Around 2017-2021: from ontology to ecology

His attention gradually shifts.

Instead of asking

"What is the Web?"

he begins asking

"What kinds of worlds does the Web make possible?"

This is where his collaborations with Diego Landivar and Emmanuel Bonnet become central.

The object of study is no longer digital technology alone.

It becomes:

- infrastructures
- industrial systems
- energy systems
- logistics
- institutions
- territories

Digital technology becomes just one component of a much larger socio-technical metabolism.

This is already very close to Donella Meadows' systemic perspective.

3. Redirection

Probably the biggest conceptual innovation since the thesis is **redirection**.

This is much stronger than:

- sustainability
- green IT
- responsible innovation
- ethical AI

Those all implicitly assume the continuation of the existing technological trajectory.

Redirection starts from another premise:

Certain technological trajectories cannot be sustained and therefore must eventually be abandoned, transformed or dismantled.

This is a very different intervention point.

Instead of optimizing systems,
one asks

Which systems should continue existing at all?

That is a Meadows-style intervention at the level of system goals rather than parameters.

4. The importance of attachments

The preprint he describes as "very important for my conception de la redirection" appears to deepen one of the key questions that has emerged over the last several years: why are socio-technical systems so difficult to redirect?

The answer is increasingly not:

- economics
- engineering
- incentives

Instead it is:

attachments.

People become attached to:

- infrastructures
- habits
- institutions
- expectations
- identities
- capabilities

Technology survives because entire forms of life have crystallized around it.

That makes redirection resemble anthropology or political ecology more than engineering. This emphasis is reflected in recent work around ecological redirection, where the practical task is to identify attachments before deciding what can be transformed or renounced. ([arXiv](#))

5. "Zombie technologies"

His July 2026 essay *La magie noire des technologies zombies* is, in my view, one of the clearest syntheses of this evolution. ([AOC media - Analyse Opinion Critique](#))

The central move is striking.

Technologies persist not merely because of:

- sunk costs
- lock-in
- capitalism
- path dependence

They persist because they exercise **enchantment**.

They promise power.

Distance disappears.

Resources appear instantly.

Computation feels immaterial.

Logistics feels invisible.

Cloud computing feels weightless.

The technology functions almost like ritual magic.

This "magic" hides the enormous material apparatus:

- mines
- shipping
- electrical grids
- data centers
- maintenance
- labor
- geological extraction

When Monnin calls these "zombie technologies", he is not saying they are obsolete.

He is saying they continue operating despite becoming incompatible with the temporal constraints of the Earth system. They remain socially alive while ecologically "dead." ([AOC media - Analyse Opinion Critique](#))

6. Why this is a continuation of the thesis

There is a deep continuity.

In 2013:

the Web hides infrastructure.

In 2026:

all industrial technologies hide infrastructure.

In 2013:

digital objects appear autonomous.

In 2026:

technological systems appear autonomous.

In 2013:

hyperlinks conceal maintenance work.

In 2026:

global logistics conceals planetary extraction.

The underlying philosophical gesture is almost identical:

make visible what successful infrastructures render invisible.

7. Connections with Donella Meadows

The overlap with Meadows is surprisingly strong.

Meadows	Monnin
feedback loops	attachments
resilience	maintenance
leverage points	redirection
system purpose	ecological compatibility
paradigms	technological enchantment
delays	geological time

Where Meadows remains largely cybernetic, Monnin adds:

- history
- materiality
- anthropology
- philosophy
- political ecology

His work could almost be read as a phenomenology of leverage points.

8. Connections with AI agents

This is where I think your earlier questions become particularly interesting.

An AI-agent ecosystem naturally tends toward increasing:

- automation
- delegation
- infrastructural complexity
- invisible dependencies
- irreversible commitments

Monnin would likely ask questions such as:

- Which new attachments are these agents creating?
- Which infrastructures become impossible to abandon?
- What maintenance burden is silently accumulating?
- What planetary costs become invisible?
- Under what circumstances should an agent be deliberately removed rather than improved?

This is a substantially different research agenda from current agent engineering. Instead of maximizing capability, it asks how to preserve the possibility of future redirection.

9. A possible synthesis with IEML

This is where I think your earlier intuition about Pierre Lévy becomes particularly interesting.

The two projects operate at almost opposite levels.

IEML attempts to formalize semantic relations, making collective intelligence computable through explicit semantic structures.

Monnin increasingly analyzes the material and ecological conditions that make those semantic systems possible—and sometimes impossible to sustain.

A productive synthesis would look something like:

- **IEML:** formal representation of meanings, concepts and transformations.
- **Meadows:** formal representation of feedback structures and leverage points.
- **Monnin:** representation of ecological constraints, attachments, maintenance and renunciation.
- **AI agents:** operational mechanisms capable of acting within those representations.

That combination would shift agent architectures away from pure optimization toward **governance under ecological constraints**. Agents would not merely infer goals and execute plans; they would reason about dependencies, maintenance obligations, irreversibility, and opportunities for redirection. In that sense, Monnin's recent work supplies a missing normative and ecological layer that complements both Meadows' systems thinking and IEML's semantic formalism.

Confidence: 0.95